

upcoming OS refreshes such as iOS 8, Android L, BlackBerry 10.3, etc., we will still attempt to get all the Android variants in and pit them against each other. For now, for this test, we're really looking at stock Android 4.4.4 vs iOS 7.1.2 vs Windows Phone 8.1 vs BlackBerry OS 10.2. We will also be including HTC's Sense 6.0 port of Android to give you an idea of the differences between vanilla Android and a modded one.

We will also be giving you this completed sheet in the DVD and putting it up online, so that it can be a ready reference for you to fill in details yourself, perhaps about new OSes as and when you're exposed to them – and we will also keep this list updated ourselves with OSes we're looking forward to including Amazon's Fire Phone, Ubuntu Touch, Firefox OS, etc.

ROUND 1: FIGHT

As we mentioned earlier, we've broken this test into two parts, the first is the more time-consuming, detailed study of every OS and how you interface with it, how many steps are taken for each task, etc. Round 2 will expand this to even more OSes and versions of OSes such as Android, and then also evaluate things such as one-handed use, and looking at more subjective things such as whether swipes are preferred to taps for various settings.

We've included two tables here, one is a short table that will decide the winners based on the scoring with all the boring details removed, and another which is the full blown table for just one of the 10 aspects we tested – Photography. We're doing this on purpose to give you a proper sense of the detail and enormity of the task we undertook, and also for another reason:

DISCOVERY

While undergoing this test, we first had people familiar with their OS fill a sheet. So for example, Robert filled in BlackBerry, Anirudh filled in KitKat 4.4.4, Prakrit filled in iOS, etc. Then we had someone else who doesn't use those phones recheck each step, and also got our interns to search for shortcuts for each step for all OSes and to try and find faults in the process.

What we discovered was that although we think ourselves well-versed with our OS of choice, there are always hidden features we've never really thought of or used earlier. We also discovered that although we go about doing something a certain way, it doesn't mean that's the easiest and fastest way of doing so.

An example here is Siddharth pointing out that the easiest way to call a contact on Android is to go to the dialler, type out the name in the old style – for "Jayesh", just type 5 2 9 3 7 4 (by the time you have

typed half those numbers "Jayesh" will show up), select and call. While most of us would do it the old fashioned way – go to Contacts > Search > type "Jayesh" > Select Jayesh's contact > Call.

It's the coming together of different perspectives and brains that made this rather rigorous exercise fun, and it was also a myth busting experience, as many of us were exposed to how other OSes handle the same task. It was an exercise that opened up our eyes to the flexibility and power of other OSes and each and every one of us developed a healthy respect for an OS that we might have otherwise brushed aside. Of course, we can all accuse each OS from stealing something from the other, but stolen or not, the OS with the best implemented features wins.

FINALLY, THE SCORING AND WINNERS

Now here's what you've been waiting for. Based on the extensive sheets and scoring, we've arrived at the following results:

BROWSING

For those looking for the premiere browsing experience and security on the phone, the results are in and Android is the winner. The HTC Sense OS actually pipped Android, despite running with the stock Android browser. Android was a fair bit ahead of iOS in second,

HOW WE TEST OSes

So how do you go about "testing" an OS? For one, we couldn't run benchmarks, because that's a test of hardware running an OS and not really a test of the OS itself. So we decided that we would need to break this down into the components of what we use mobile phones for, and how we use them the most.

So how do we use our phones the most these days:

- Browsing to find content to read and research
- Good old email to communicate for work and personal reasons
- Messaging, IM and social networking, obviously
- Customising our phones to be exactly as we want them to be, and thus we gave importance to settings and not just what was possible but how easy it was to find

- Managing contacts and the dialler to call and keep in touch
 - Photography, obviously, as we now click more pictures with smart-phones than dedicated cameras
 - Notifications, and being alerted and updated about what's happening
 - The lock screen of our phones (which some claim will be the most important screen going forwards) as it is the real summary of what's happening as soon as we look at our phones
 - Searching for things (on or off the phone), because we're all used to using search for absolutely everything these days
 - Videos that we take and then want to share with friends
- Are these the only way we use our phones? Of course not, some of us may find creative uses for phones, such as using them to read long